



ESTEVEZ INTELLIGENCE



A WHITEPAPER BY ESTEVEZ INTELLIGENCE

The AI-Leveraged Service Business

How an asset-light dispatch company became a repeatable method for building — and scaling — AI-run businesses.

Concept & Method · June 2026
Case study: Northbound Dispatch
Barrie, Ontario, Canada

Applied intelligence for real-world businesses.



The Thesis

// why this matters

Thousands of local service industries are large, fragmented, and still run on phone calls, spreadsheets, and memory. The work of *coordinating* them — matching supply to demand, negotiating, scheduling, following up, invoicing — is repetitive, rules-based, and perfectly suited to AI. **Estevez Intelligence builds businesses that own the coordination layer, not the assets**, and wrap it in an AI stack that lets one operator do the work of three.

The pattern in one line: pick a fragmented, manual service industry → enter asset-light (broker the service, don't buy the trucks/equipment) → build the system of record → layer AI automation on the repetitive work → reach operator leverage of 3x → productize the AI layer as a second revenue line.

3x

trucks per operator vs. a traditional dispatcher (15–20 vs. 5–7)

~\$150

monthly cost to start — asset-light, no vehicles owned

Day 1

legal & cash-flow positive at the very first customer

The rest of this paper walks the concept through a live example — **Northbound Dispatch** — then extracts the method so it can be pointed at the next industry.

01 The Concept — Case Study: Northbound Dispatch

Northbound Dispatch finds, negotiates, and confirms freight loads for independent truck owner-operators across Ontario and cross-border lanes. It is a **dispatch service, not a freight broker** — carriers keep their own authority, insurance, and compliance — so no license or bond is required and the business can start immediately, legally, with almost no capital.

The problem it coordinates away

Owner-operators are excellent drivers and poor freight-finders. Empty trucks lose money, load boards are a full-time job, and brokers negotiate against them. A dispatcher keeps the truck loaded at the best rate so the driver just drives. That coordination is the product.

Why it is a good business

- **Asset-light.** No trucks, no lot, no inventory. Revenue is a fee on coordination, not a margin on owned assets.
- **Recurring & week-to-week.** 8% of gross load revenue, or a \$200/week flat per truck — predictable, compounding as carriers are added.
- **Low cost to serve.** Sub-\$300/month tooling. One active carrier covers the entire monthly cost in a single week.
- **AI-defensible.** The automation layer is the moat — it widens every month as more of the manual playbook is handed to software.



The moat: operator leverage

A traditional dispatcher manages 5–7 trucks because the work is manual. Northbound's stack — a voice agent for inbound calls, an agent that scans and scores load boards, and workflow automations for onboarding, alerts, and invoicing — targets **15–20 trucks per operator**. Same fee per truck, three times the throughput. That delta is the entire thesis, proven in one vertical.

Unit economics (planning estimates). A blended ~\$300/truck/week fee → ~\$1,290/truck/month. Five active carriers ≈ \$6.5k/month; fifteen ≈ \$19k/month — all on a single operator once the AI layer carries the repetitive load.



02 Why the Model Works — Five Structural Advantages

#	Advantage	What it means
1	Asset-light entry	Coordinate the service instead of owning the means of delivery — near-zero capital, no balance-sheet risk.
2	AI operator leverage	Software absorbs the repetitive coordination; one person serves 3x the customers at the same quality.
3	Recurring revenue	Weekly, cancellable fees that compound with each customer added — a services annuity, not project work.
4	Low customer-acquisition cost	Local, high-intent channels (referrals, schools, community groups) reach customers who need the service now.
5	Productizable stack	The AI layer built to run the service can be sold to others in the industry — a second, higher-margin revenue line.

Crucially, the advantages stack. Asset-light keeps capital near zero; AI leverage keeps headcount near zero; recurring revenue keeps cash flow predictable; low CAC keeps growth cheap; and productization turns the internal tooling into an external asset. The same five hold for any industry that fits the entry criteria below.

03 The Estevez Intelligence Method

The repeatable blueprint that turns the case study into a process. Each step is sequenced so the business is profitable and useful *before* the automation is built — the AI is an accelerant on a model that already works manually, never a prerequisite.

- 1 Pick the right industry**
 Fragmented supply (many small independent operators), a manual coordination bottleneck, a recurring need, and relationship-driven demand. The more it runs on phone calls and spreadsheets, the better the fit.
- 2 Enter asset-light**
 Sell the coordination, not the asset. Broker / dispatch / arrange the service so there is no fleet, inventory, or property to finance. Confirm the legal lane (e.g. dispatch ≠ broker) so you can start immediately.
- 3 Build the system of record first**
 A simple CRM that captures supply, demand, status, and money. It is the single source of truth a human runs today and the AI reads/writes tomorrow. No system of record, no automation later.
- 4 Write the manual playbook**
 Document the daily operating rhythm a human follows end to end. This is both the operations manual and the exact specification the automations will implement, task by task.



5

Layer AI by time-saved

Automate in order of hours returned: workflow automations (onboarding, alerts, invoicing) → an inbound voice agent → a matching/scoring agent on the data feeds. Each release hands more of the playbook to software.

6

Reach operator leverage

Compound the automations until one operator profitably serves ~3x a traditional operator. This is the margin engine and the defensible moat.

7

Productize the stack

Package the AI layer as a product for others in the same industry — a second, higher-margin revenue line that is field-tested by your own operation.

Sequencing rule. Manual-but-working beats automated-but-fragile. Ship steps 1–4 to a paying customer first; steps 5–7 are where the leverage and the enterprise value are created.

04 The Shared Automation Stack

The same components power every business in the portfolio. Building them once and reusing them is what makes each new vertical cheaper and faster than the last.

Layer	Role	Reused across the portfolio
System of record	CRM / tracker — supply, demand, status, money.	Schema adapts per industry; the pattern is identical.
Workflow automation	Onboarding, reminders, alerts, invoicing (n8n).	Same engine, swapped triggers and templates.
Voice agent	Inbound calls answered, logged, escalated (Sarah).	One architecture (telephony + voice), re-skinned per brand.
Matching / scoring agent	Scans feeds, ranks opportunities, drafts offers.	Generic 'score & rank' engine pointed at new data sources.
Human-in-the-loop	Approvals via chat before anything goes out.	Same guardrail pattern keeps quality high while scaling.

Because these are shared, the marginal cost of standing up business #2, #3, #4 falls each time. The first vertical pays to build the stack; every vertical after rents it for nearly free.



05 Scaling to Similar Businesses

The method is industry-agnostic. Any market that is fragmented, manual, and recurring is a candidate. The table maps the same pattern onto several local-service industries — what you *don't* own, where the AI leverage sits, and the unit you scale.

Industry	Asset you DON'T own	Where AI leverage sits	Unit scaled
Truck dispatch	The trucks	Load matching, rate negotiation, dispatch ops	Trucks / operator
Home-services estimating	The crews	Instant AI quotes, lead triage, follow-up	Quotes / day
Cleaning & janitorial	The cleaners	Scheduling, dispatch, client comms	Jobs / coordinator
Last-mile courier	The vehicles	Route/parcel matching, driver comms	Deliveries / operator
Equipment rental brokerage	The equipment	Availability matching, booking, billing	Bookings / operator
Field-service trades	The technicians	Intake voice agent, scheduling, invoicing	Tickets / dispatcher

Live in the portfolio already: Northbound Dispatch (truck dispatch) and the Golden Maple + estimate-ai pairing (home-services estimating). Same stack, same method, different verticals — the proof that the blueprint travels.



06 The Economics of Replication

Each new vertical is cheaper, faster, and lower-risk than the one before, because the expensive part — the automation stack and the operating method — is already built and paid for.

1st

vertical funds the shared stack

↓ **cost**each new vertical reuses it for
near-free**2 lines**services revenue + productized
software

The portfolio flywheel

- **Build once, deploy many.** The stack built for vertical #1 is reused by #2 and #3 — engineering cost amortizes across the whole portfolio.
- **Learnings compound.** Every operational lesson, prompt, and workflow improves all businesses at once.
- **Two revenue lines per vertical.** The service generates cash; the productized AI layer is sold to others in that industry.
- **Capital-light growth.** Asset-light + shared stack means scaling adds verticals, not balance-sheet risk.

The compounding insight: you are not building one company — you are building a method and a stack, then pointing them at one fragmented industry after another. The moat is the machine that builds the businesses.

07 Risks & Guardrails

Risk	Guardrail
Regulatory / licensing confusion	Confirm the legal lane per vertical (e.g. dispatch ≠ broker); position clearly; verify counterparties' compliance.
Automating before product-market fit	Sequencing rule: manual-but-working first; automate only proven, repetitive steps.
Over-automation / quality slip	Human-in-the-loop approval gates on anything customer-facing until trust is earned.
Key-person dependence	Document everything; the stack and playbooks reduce reliance on any single human.
Spreading too thin	Prove and stabilize one vertical before opening the next; reuse, don't reinvent.



08 In Short

Northbound Dispatch is not just a dispatch company — it is a working proof of a repeatable method: **own the coordination, not the assets; run it on an AI stack that gives one operator the output of three; then productize that stack and point the whole machine at the next fragmented industry.** That is what Estevez Intelligence builds.

Estevez Intelligence · Applied intelligence for real-world businesses. · yorkis@estevezintelligence.com
· Barrie, Ontario